

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

State & Varna Society in the Age of the Buddha - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

State & Varna Society in the Age of the Buddha	
01. DEFINING THE AGE OF THE BUDDHA: HORIZON, CHRONOLOGY AND CAUTIONS Interpretation: Age of the Buddha is a cultural construct, not a scientific one.	02. SOURCES AND EVIDENCE-METHOD MATRIX Methodology: Use a matrix to evaluate sources and methods.
03. SECOND URBANISATION: DEFINITION AND MATERIAL SETTING Interpretation: Second urbanisation is a process, not a state.	04. NEW TOWNS AND SITE-SPECIFIC ARCHAEOLOGICAL CAUTION Interpretation: Archaeological evidence is site-specific and not general.
05. AGRICULTURE, RURAL SETTLEMENTS AND SURPLUS Caution: Archaeological evidence is often indirect and not direct.	06. CRAFTS, GUILDS, TRADE, COINS AND CREDIT Interpretation: Crafts, guilds, trade, coins and credit are not the same.
07. STATE FORMATION: A CONJUNCTURAL CAUSAL FLOW Interpretation: State formation is a process, not a state.	08. JAMHAPADA, MAHAJAMHAPADA AND TERRITORIALITY Interpretation: Jamhapa and Mahajamhapa are not the same.
09. MONARCHICAL INSTITUTIONS, OFFICIALS AND LOCAL ADMINISTRATION Interpretation: Monarchical institutions are not the same.	10. TAXATION, LAW, ORDER AND ADJUDICATION Interpretation: Taxation, law, order and adjudication are not the same.
11. ARMY, FORTIFICATION, DIPLOMACY AND WARFARE Interpretation: Army, fortification, diplomacy and warfare are not the same.	12. KINGSHIP, PROTECTION AND POLITICAL LEGITIMATION Interpretation: Kingship, protection and political legitimation are not the same.
13. GANA-SANGHA INSTITUTIONS AND SOCIAL BASES Interpretation: Gana-sangha institutions are not the same.	14. MONARCHY AND GANA-SANGHA COMPARED Caution: The material use of monarchy does not prove that.
15. VARNA DIVERSITY AND TEXTUAL FORMULATIONS Interpretation: The same source is used for different purposes.	16. VARNA, JATI, OCCUPATION, STATUS, CLASS AND URBANE DISTINGUISHING Interpretation: Varna, jati, occupation, status, class and urbane distinguishing are not the same.
17. VARNA NORM VERSUS SOCIAL PRACTICE Interpretation: The relationship of varna norms and social practice is not the same.	18. BRAHMANA-SHASTRIYA TENSION AND ACCOMMODATION Interpretation: Brahmana-shastriya tension and accommodation are not the same.
19. SOCIAL PYRAMID WITH CAVEATS Interpretation: Social pyramid is not a simple model.	20. GHANAPATI, SETHI AND NEW ECONOMIC ELITES Interpretation: Ghanapati, sethi and new economic elites are not the same.
21. ARTISANS, MERCHANTS, CULTIVATORS AND CORPORATE GROUPS Interpretation: Artisans, merchants, cultivators and corporate groups are not the same.	22. LABOUR, DEPENDENCY, SLAVERY AND EXCLUDED GROUPS Interpretation: Labour, dependency, slavery and excluded groups are not the same.
23. FOREST, TRIBAL AND PERIPHERAL GROUPS; REGIONAL VARIATION Interpretation: Forest, tribal and peripheral groups are not the same.	24. FAMILY, KINSHIP, MARRIAGE AND INHERITANCE Interpretation: Family, kinship, marriage and inheritance are not the same.
25. WOMEN'S ROLES, STATUS AND THE LIMITS OF EVIDENCE Interpretation: Women's roles, status and the limits of evidence are not the same.	26. URBAN-RURAL SOCIAL NETWORK AND CHANGING ECONOMIC RELATIONS Interpretation: Urban-rural social network and changing economic relations are not the same.
27. BUDDHISM AND JAINISM AS SOCIAL RESPONSES WITHIN THE AGE Interpretation: Buddhism and Jainism are not the same.	28. JAIN FOURFOLD COMMUNITY, LAY VOWS AND SOCIAL LIMITS Interpretation: Jain fourfold community, lay vows and social limits are not the same.
29. PATRONAGE, MONASTIC-LAY RELATIONS AND SOCIAL APPEAL Interpretation: Patronage, monastic-lay relations and social appeal are not the same.	30. SOCIAL MOBILITY, OCCUPATIONAL CHANGE AND TEXTUAL CONTRADICTIONS Interpretation: Social mobility, occupational change and textual contradictions are not the same.
31. LATER VEDIC SOCIETY AND BUDDHISM-AGE SOCIETY COMPARED Interpretation: Later Vedic society and Buddhism-age society are not the same.	32. BRIDGE TO THE MAURYAN STATE WITHOUT TELEOLONY Interpretation: Bridge to the Mauryan state without teleology is not the same.
33. HISTORIOGRAPHY: MATERIALIST, TEXTUAL AND FURTHER INTERPRETATIONS Interpretation: Historiography is not the same.	34. CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE WITHOUT PRESENTIST EQUIVOCANCE Interpretation: Contemporary relevance without presentist equivocation is not the same.
35. TERMILOLOGY GAINS, MEMORY HOOPS AND INTEGRATED UPSC TRAPS Interpretation: Terminology gains, memory hoops and integrated UPSC traps are not the same.	

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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State & Varna Society in the Age of the Buddha - Complete Topic Package

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Hard MCQ 01 - Historical horizon

Which is the safest definition of the 'Age of the Buddha' for social history?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	A sixth-fifth century BCE core within a wider c. 600-200 BCE transformation	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A precisely dated lifetime recorded contemporaneously	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	A uniform all-India century beginning in 600 BCE	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A synonym for the Mauryan Empire	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - A sixth-fifth century BCE core within a wider c. 600-200 BCE transformation.
- EXPLANATION: The label is heuristic: political, textual and archaeological processes have overlapping but non-identical chronologies.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 1 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 1 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Historical horizon.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 02 - Pali canon

Which source-use statement is most defensible?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	They can be read as a population census	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	The early Nikayas and Vinaya preserve important early material but are composite monastic texts	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	They are court chronicles written during every reported event	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	The Jatakas in present form are uniformly sixth-century BCE	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - The early Nikayas and Vinaya preserve important early material but are composite monastic texts.
- EXPLANATION: Genre and transmission matter. Early material is valuable, but the canon is neither homogeneous nor a verbatim transcript.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 2 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 2 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Pali canon.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 03 - Jataka caution

Why should Jataka detail be used cautiously for the sixth century BCE?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	It is purely archaeological evidence	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	It contains no social information	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Its present textual form is substantially later even if some motifs are older	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	It was composed only in Sanskrit	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Its present textual form is substantially later even if some motifs are older.
- EXPLANATION: Older legends may survive, but later compilation means details need corroboration.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 3 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 3 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Jataka caution.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 04 - Dharmasutra method

A Dharmasutra rule is strongest evidence for:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Universal compliance across India	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	The material culture of an excavated settlement	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	The exact verdict of every royal court	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A Brahmanical normative attempt to regulate social practice	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - A Brahmanical normative attempt to regulate social practice.
- EXPLANATION: Prescription reveals ideals and anxieties, not automatic practice.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 4 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 4 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Dharmasutra method.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 05 - NBPW

Which statement about NBPW is correct?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	It is a material horizon associated with early-historic urbanisation, not a sufficient cause of it	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	It proves a settlement was a Buddhist monastery	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	It began everywhere in the same year	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	It is the diagnostic pottery of Mature Harappa	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - It is a material horizon associated with early-historic urbanisation, not a sufficient cause of it.
- EXPLANATION: NBPW is a useful ceramic marker with site-specific chronology and no automatic ethnic or institutional identity.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 5 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 5 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: NBPW.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 06 - Urban criteria

Which bundle best identifies early urbanisation?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Pottery alone	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Settlement hierarchy, specialised crafts, exchange, political functions and surplus	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	A large population estimate alone	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	One literary palace description	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Settlement hierarchy, specialised crafts, exchange, political functions and surplus.
- EXPLANATION: Urbanism is a system; no single marker is sufficient.

- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 6 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 6 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Urban criteria.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 07 - Coin evidence

Which set consists of Pali coin terms used in the package?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	dinara, tanka, jital, dam	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	nishka, suvarna, dinara, rupiya as identical coins	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	kahapana, nikkha, kamsa, masaka	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	karshapana, pagoda, fanam, mohur only	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - kahapana, nikkha, kamsa, masaka.
- EXPLANATION: Pali textual terms converge with punch-marked coin archaeology; precise denomination equivalence still needs context.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 7 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 7 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Coin evidence.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 08 - Monetisation

The beginning of coin use implies that:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Barter ended immediately	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Coin distribution became uniform	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Every peasant paid all taxes in silver	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Money, barter, kind payments and credit could coexist	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Money, barter, kind payments and credit could coexist.
- EXPLANATION: Monetisation was qualitative but uneven.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 8 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 8 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Monetisation.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 09 - Janapada

Janapada is best understood as:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	A territorial domain and its people, with varying institutional depth	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A universal gana assembly	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Only a capital city	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A modern sovereign nation-state	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - A territorial domain and its people, with varying institutional depth.
- EXPLANATION: The term links people and territory but does not guarantee centralised bureaucracy.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 9 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 9 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Janapada.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 10 - State capacity

Which factor most directly converts agrarian surplus into sustained state power?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Ritual claims without a treasury	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Institutions that assess, collect and mobilise resources	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Soil fertility without labour	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Iron objects without political organisation	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Institutions that assess, collect and mobilise resources.
- EXPLANATION: Surplus must be produced and appropriated through institutions.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 10 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 10 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: State capacity.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 11 - Officials

What is the safest inference from mahamatta/mahamachcha and other office terms?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	There was no village administration	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A Mauryan-style uniform bureaucracy already existed	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Pre-Mauryan monarchies had functional differentiation, though standardisation is uncertain	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	All officials were hereditary clan members	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Pre-Mauryan monarchies had functional differentiation, though standardisation is uncertain.
- EXPLANATION: Titles show differentiation, not a complete empire-wide organisation chart.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 11 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 11 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Officials.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 12 - Tax rates

Which statement about land-revenue shares is correct?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Taxes were collected only in coin	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Brahmanical texts never discuss revenue	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	One-sixth was the only rate in every polity	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Normative rates varied, including 1/10, 1/8 and 1/6 in one Dharmasutra discussion	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Normative rates varied, including 1/10, 1/8 and 1/6 in one Dharmasutra discussion.
- EXPLANATION: Variation in normative rates blocks universal claims.

- **ELIMINATION:** reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- **ROTATION CHECK:** position 12 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- **EVIDENCE RULE:** identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 12 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Tax rates.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 13 - Nanda army

How should large Nanda army figures in classical traditions be used?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	As evidence of remembered scale, with exaggeration and genre cautions	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	As contemporary inscriptions	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	As audited official statistics	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	As proof that elephants alone caused Magadhan success	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- **CORRECT ANSWER:** A - As evidence of remembered scale, with exaggeration and genre cautions.
- **EXPLANATION:** Later numerical traditions indicate reputation, not precise payroll data.
- **ELIMINATION:** reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- **ROTATION CHECK:** position 13 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- **EVIDENCE RULE:** identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 13 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Nanda army.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 14 - Fortifications

A rampart or palisade most securely indicates:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	A democratic constitution	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Concern with defence, control or separation, subject to phase dating	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Permanent warfare	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A named king built it	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Concern with defence, control or separation, subject to phase dating.
- EXPLANATION: Material evidence must not be over-attributed.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 14 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 14 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Fortifications.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 15 - Diplomacy

The Vassakara-Vajji episode in the Mahaparinibbana Sutta is best used to show:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	The absence of warfare	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A verbatim war cabinet record	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	A textual tradition linking confederate cohesion and diplomatic subversion	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Vajji universal franchise	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - A textual tradition linking confederate cohesion and diplomatic subversion.
- EXPLANATION: It is a politically suggestive, didactic narrative.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 15 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 15 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Diplomacy.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 16 - Legitimation

Which pair correctly describes plural legitimation?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	NBPW and PGW as dynasties	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Slavery and wage labour as royal titles	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Coins and pottery as moral doctrines	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Kshatriya protection/lineage and Brahmana ritual/dharma	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Kshatriya protection/lineage and Brahmana ritual/dharma.
- EXPLANATION: Power could be justified through lineage, ritual, protection and ethical patronage.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 16 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 16 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Legitimation.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 17 - Gana nature

The gana-sanghas of this period were principally:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Oligarchic corporate polities dominated by aristocratic lineages	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Modern mass democracies	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Merchant guilds ruling every city	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Monasteries without territory	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Oligarchic corporate polities dominated by aristocratic lineages.
- EXPLANATION: Assembly government did not imply equal citizenship.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 17 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 17 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Gana nature.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 18 - Santhagara

Santhagara refers to:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	A Buddhist monsoon retreat	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	The assembly hall of a gana/sangha	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	A royal land tax	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A coin denomination	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - The assembly hall of a gana/sangha.
- EXPLANATION: The term anchors corporate political procedure.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 18 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 18 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Santhagara.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 19 - Salaka

In assembly procedure, salakas were:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Vedic sacrifices	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Elephant taxes	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Voting pieces, with later textual/monastic analogy cautions	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Land deeds	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Voting pieces, with later textual/monastic analogy cautions.
- EXPLANATION: Procedure is evidence of institutionalised elite deliberation.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 19 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 19 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Salaka.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 20 - Gana social base

Who was generally outside effective political participation in gana assemblies?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Every treasurer	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	All Kshatriya lineage heads	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Only the chief	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Women and most non-elite residents such as artisans, labourers and slaves	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Women and most non-elite residents such as artisans, labourers and slaves.
- EXPLANATION: Political rights followed aristocratic lineage, not residence.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 20 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 20 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Gana social base.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 21 - Rank debate

Buddhist and Jaina texts often:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Place Kshatriya above Brahmana while weakening birth-based spiritual sanction	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Erase all status distinctions from lay society	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Make setthis Brahmanas by definition	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Reject kingship everywhere	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Place Kshatriya above Brahmana while weakening birth-based spiritual sanction.
- EXPLANATION: Textual rank critique is real but not social abolition.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 21 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 21 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Rank debate.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 22 - Varna-jati

Which distinction is correct?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Jati has only four fixed ranks	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Varna is a fourfold normative order; jati comprises numerous lived hereditary groups	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Varna is an archaeological pottery type	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Varna and jati are exact synonyms	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Varna is a fourfold normative order; jati comprises numerous lived hereditary groups.
- EXPLANATION: Their overlap must not erase their different scale and operation.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 22 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 22 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Varna-jati.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 23 - Apad-dharma

Discussion of apad-dharma most strongly suggests:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Varna prescriptions never mattered	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Occupation was unrelated to status	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Ideal occupations were crossed in practice and normative theory created controlled exceptions	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	All occupations were freely chosen	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Ideal occupations were crossed in practice and normative theory created controlled exceptions.
- EXPLANATION: Exception reveals negotiation around a powerful norm.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 23 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 23 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Apad-dharma.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 24 - Gahapati

In key early Pali social usage, gahapati denotes:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Only any married male	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A slave captured in war	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	A gana chief	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A wealthy property-holder/producer and household head	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - A wealthy property-holder/producer and household head.
- EXPLANATION: The term often signals landed/productive wealth.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 24 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 24 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Gahapati.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 25 - Setthi

Setthi is best understood as:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	An urban high-level businessman/financier with influence	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A Buddhist monk	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	A synonym for every peasant	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A village watchman	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - An urban high-level businessman/financier with influence.
- EXPLANATION: Setthi and gahapati are related elite terms but not interchangeable.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 25 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 25 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Setthi.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 26 - Corporate groups

Which terms can refer to corporate/professional organisations?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	bhaga and bali	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	shreni and puga	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	dasa and dasi	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	sapinda and gotra	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - shreni and puga.
- EXPLANATION: Corporate vocabulary varies; later Jataka detail needs dating caution.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 26 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 26 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Corporate groups.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 27 - Cultivators

Which picture of cultivators is safest?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	All were landless	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	All were wealthy gahapatis	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	They ranged from small households to large landholders using hired/dependent labour	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	They paid no dues	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - They ranged from small households to large landholders using hired/dependent labour.
- EXPLANATION: Class differentiation existed within agrarian production.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 27 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 27 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Cultivators.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 28 - Labour terms

Which pairing is correct?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	dasa - merchant; kammakara - king	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Both always mean identical chattel status	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	dasi - guild head; kammakara - priest	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	dasa/dasi - slave/dependent; kammakara - wage worker	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - dasa/dasi - slave/dependent; kammakara - wage worker.
- EXPLANATION: Terms distinguish forms of dependence, though the compound can blur them.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 28 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 28 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Labour terms.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 29 - Excluded groups

Which is the safest statement about Chandala evidence?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Early texts show severe stigma, while the term asprishya for a social group is attested later	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Every Shudra was called Chandala	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Untouchability can be reconstructed only from modern analogy	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Chandala always meant forest chief	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Early texts show severe stigma, while the term asprishya for a social group is attested later.
- EXPLANATION: Do not overdate terminology or collapse graded exclusions.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 29 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 29 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Excluded groups.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 30 - Forest groups

Why are forest groups hard to reconstruct?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Archaeology cannot study forests	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Elite agrarian-state texts marginalise their own voices	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	They had no political role	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	They disappeared by 600 BCE	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Elite agrarian-state texts marginalise their own voices.
- EXPLANATION: Source imbalance requires careful inference from exchange and conflict.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.

- ROTATION CHECK: position 30 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 30 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Forest groups.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 31 - Kinship

Which term denotes an extended patrilineal family in the discussion?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	santhagara	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	shulka	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	kula	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	kahapana	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - kula.
- EXPLANATION: Kula, nati, gotra and sapinda organise different kin dimensions.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 31 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 31 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Kinship.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 32 - Marriage sources

The eight marriage types in Dharmasutras are:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Coin-weight categories	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Buddhist monastic offices	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	An official census of equal practices	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A graded normative classification of diverse unions	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - A graded normative classification of diverse unions.
- EXPLANATION: Classification reveals diversity and hierarchy, not frequency.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 32 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 32 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Marriage sources.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 33 - Inheritance

Which broad tendency is best supported?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Patrilineal inheritance privileged sons/male kin, with limited and debated women's claims	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Daughters always inherited equally	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Women had no movable property categories	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	The state never claimed heirless property	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Patrilineal inheritance privileged sons/male kin, with limited and debated women's claims.
- EXPLANATION: Texts vary; stri-dhana roots coexist with male priority.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 33 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 33 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Inheritance.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 34 - Women and ritual

Which statement is correct?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Women were excluded from every rite	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Some Grihyasutras allow women certain domestic rites but not independent major-sacrifice agency	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	All wives were nuns	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Women controlled gana assemblies	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Some Grihyasutras allow women certain domestic rites but not independent major-sacrifice agency.
- EXPLANATION: Agency and constraint must be stated together.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 34 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 34 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Women and ritual.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 35 - Nuns

The admission of women to renunciant orders shows:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Complete gender equality	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Women gained gana citizenship	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	A genuine alternative religious path within continuing institutional gender hierarchy	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	The end of marriage	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - A genuine alternative religious path within continuing institutional gender hierarchy.
- EXPLANATION: Access did not erase patriarchy.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 35 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 35 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Nuns.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 36 - Urban-rural

Which relation best describes town and countryside?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Villages had no markets	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Only religious ideas moved between them	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Cities replaced villages	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Mutual dependence in food, tools, markets and taxes, structured by inequality	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Mutual dependence in food, tools, markets and taxes, structured by inequality.
- EXPLANATION: The urban system rested on rural surplus.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 36 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 36 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Urban-rural.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 37 - Religious critique

Buddhist critique of birth-based status is best assessed as:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	A challenge to spiritual/ethical hierarchy that did not abolish lay social distinctions	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A rejection of all householders	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	A ban on royal patronage	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A legal abolition of all jatis	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - A challenge to spiritual/ethical hierarchy that did not abolish lay social distinctions.
- EXPLANATION: Doctrine, monastic admission and lay society must be separated.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 37 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 37 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Religious critique.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 38 - Admission limits

Why did early sangha rules restrict entry of slaves and debtors?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Only Brahmanas could join	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	They recognised existing claims of masters/creditors and required prior release or repayment	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Coins were banned	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	The sangha supported hereditary slavery as doctrine	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - They recognised existing claims of masters/creditors and required prior release or repayment.
- EXPLANATION: The rule shows both access and institutional accommodation with lay obligations.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 38 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 38 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Admission limits.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 39 - Lay patrons

Which pair correctly identifies donor-social categories?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Only forest hunters and no elites	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Only Brahmana priests	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	gahapati/setthi and royal patrons	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Only foreign merchants	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - gahapati/setthi and royal patrons.
- EXPLANATION: Patronage was socially varied but easier for surplus holders.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.

- ROTATION CHECK: position 39 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 39 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Lay patrons.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 40 - Jain context

Jainism's social appeal in this period is safest linked to:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Abolition of every hierarchy	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Rejection of all trade	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Exclusive support by one class	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Ethical discipline, renunciation, lay vows and urban-agrarian patronage without economic reductionism	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Ethical discipline, renunciation, lay vows and urban-agrarian patronage without economic reductionism.
- EXPLANATION: Context matters, but doctrine has its own soteriological logic.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 40 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 40 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Jain context.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 41 - Mobility

Which is an example of status contradiction?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	A wealthy setthi could possess influence without Brahmana ritual rank	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A monk remained a royal official by definition	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Varna and wealth always coincided	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Every artisan was politically equal	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - A wealthy setthi could possess influence without Brahmana ritual rank.
- EXPLANATION: Ritual, economic and political axes did not perfectly align.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 41 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 41 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Mobility.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 42 - Later Vedic comparison

Which feature primarily belongs to the following Buddha-age horizon rather than the core Later Vedic phase?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	PGW association	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Wider NBPW towns and punch-marked coin use	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Rajasuya ritual	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Kuru-Panchala prominence	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Wider NBPW towns and punch-marked coin use.
- EXPLANATION: Protect the chronology boundary while acknowledging regional overlap.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 42 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 42 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Later Vedic comparison.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 43 - Mauryan bridge

Which statement is safest?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Ashokan dhamma was already a sixth-century tax code	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	The Mauryan Empire was inevitable	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Mauryan rule scaled earlier Magadhan capacities but added imperial and inscriptional features	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Every pre-Mauryan title had identical Mauryan function	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Mauryan rule scaled earlier Magadhan capacities but added imperial and inscriptional features.
- EXPLANATION: Use continuity plus new scale, not teleology.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 43 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 43 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Mauryan bridge.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 44 - Materialist lens

The major strength of a materialist interpretation is that it:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Makes iron the only cause	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Denies ideology	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Treats texts as irrelevant	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Links production, surplus, class and coercive institutions	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Links production, surplus, class and coercive institutions.
- EXPLANATION: Its strongest form is multi-causal rather than deterministic.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 44 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 44 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Materialist lens.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 45 - Nationalist republic

A key caution about early nationalist writing on ganas is:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	It could project modern democratic features while rebutting colonial despotism claims	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	It relied only on carbon dating	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	It focused exclusively on women's labour	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	It denied that ganas existed	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - It could project modern democratic features while rebutting colonial despotism claims.
- EXPLANATION: Historiography explains both recovery and overstatement.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 45 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 45 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Nationalist republic.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 46 - Triangulation

Which is the best evidence combination for urban monetisation?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	A modern tourism slogan	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Pali coin vocabulary plus punch-marked coins plus settlement/craft context	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	A pottery colour without context	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A single later legend	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Pali coin vocabulary plus punch-marked coins plus settlement/craft context.
- EXPLANATION: Independent evidence classes strengthen but do not become identical.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 46 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 46 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Triangulation.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 47 - Presentism

Which sentence is unsafe?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Its institutional details require source criticism	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Vaishali is linked in texts with the oligarchic Vajji/Lichchhavi polity	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Vaishali was a democracy identical to modern constitutional India	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Modern heritage pages do not prove ancient franchise	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Vaishali was a democracy identical to modern constitutional India.
- EXPLANATION: Gana participation was aristocratic and exclusionary.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 47 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 47 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Presentism.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Hard MCQ 48 - Integrated answer

What is the strongest sequence for a 20-marker?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Pottery list -> caste claim	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Kings list -> conclusion	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Modern analogy -> ancient proof	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Horizon/sources -> material base -> institutions -> norm/practice -> social response -> limits	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Horizon/sources -> material base -> institutions -> norm/practice -> social response -> limits.
- EXPLANATION: The sequence integrates evidence and argument while preserving distinctions.

- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 48 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 48 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Integrated answer.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 49 - NBPW remedial

NBPW should not be confused with:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Mature Harappan urban pottery	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A material source requiring site chronology	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Early-historic north-Indian settlement horizons	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	A marker associated with second urbanisation	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Mature Harappan urban pottery.
- EXPLANATION: NBPW is early historic, not Harappan.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 49 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 49 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: NBPW remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 50 - Varna remedial

Which statement corrects the most common social-history error?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Only wealth mattered	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Varna, jati, occupation and class overlap but are not identical	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	All four mean birth group	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Only ritual rank mattered	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Varna, jati, occupation and class overlap but are not identical.
- EXPLANATION: Multi-axis identity is the central correction.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 50 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 50 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Varna remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 51 - Elite terms remedial

Which pairing is correct?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	gahapati - coin; setthi - tax	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	gahapati - slave; setthi - monk	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	gahapati - landed/productive wealth; setthi - urban finance/business	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Both always interchangeable	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - gahapati - landed/productive wealth; setthi - urban finance/business.
- EXPLANATION: Remember ground/production versus street/finance.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 51 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 51 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Elite terms remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 52 - Gana remedial

Calling a gana-sangha a 'republic' requires which immediate qualification?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	It had no assembly	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	It was a monarchy	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	It excluded all Kshatriyas	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	It was an oligarchic lineage polity, not modern mass democracy	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - It was an oligarchic lineage polity, not modern mass democracy.
- EXPLANATION: The qualification prevents presentism.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 52 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 52 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Gana remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 53 - Caste-abolition remedial

Which statement is most accurate?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Buddhism/Jainism challenged birth-based spiritual privilege but did not abolish lay hierarchy	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	They rejected all lay donors	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	They enacted a caste-abolition law	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	They accepted only one varna	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Buddhism/Jainism challenged birth-based spiritual privilege but did not abolish lay hierarchy.
- EXPLANATION: Separate ethical critique, admission and social practice.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 53 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 53 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Caste-abolition remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 54 - Tax remedial

Which statement about one-sixth is safest?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	It was paid everywhere only in cash	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	It is one normative rate among variants, not a universal observed rate	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	It is an archaeological measurement	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	It applied only to monks	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - It is one normative rate among variants, not a universal observed rate.
- EXPLANATION: Use rate variation as a source caution.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 54 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 54 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Tax remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 55 - Admission remedial

A slave seeking sangha admission generally had to:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Become a setthi	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Pay a land tax to the monastery	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Obtain freedom first	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Join a gana assembly	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Obtain freedom first.
- EXPLANATION: The rule recognises lay ownership/dependence.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 55 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 55 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Admission remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 56 - Jataka remedial

The present form of the Jatakas is:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	A Mauryan tax register	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	A contemporary inscription	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	An excavation report	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Later than the core Buddha-age horizon, though it may preserve older motifs	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Later than the core Buddha-age horizon, though it may preserve older motifs.
- EXPLANATION: Use corroboration and long-term perspective.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 56 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 56 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Jataka remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 57 - Gender remedial

Which inference is unsafe?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	The existence of nuns proves complete gender equality	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Women had a religious alternative	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Elite texts under-represent ordinary women	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Institutional restrictions continued	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - The existence of nuns proves complete gender equality.
- EXPLANATION: Access and equality are different claims.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 57 -> A; strict A-B-C-D sequence.

- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 57 -> A.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Gender remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 58 - Iron remedial

What is the correct causal claim about iron?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	It was absent from the Ganga valley	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	It was one enabling technology among labour, ecology, routes and institutions	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	It automatically created every state	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	It eliminated wooden tools	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: B - It was one enabling technology among labour, ecology, routes and institutions.
- EXPLANATION: Reject single-cause determinism.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 58 -> B; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 58 -> B.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Iron remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 59 - Pataliputra remedial

Which distinction is essential?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Pataliputra had no pre-Mauryan phase	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	Every wooden feature is a palace	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	Early palisade/settlement evidence must be separated from later Mauryan monumental remains	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	All Kumrahar remains are sixth-century BCE	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Early palisade/settlement evidence must be separated from later Mauryan monumental remains.
- EXPLANATION: Date the layer before attributing the institution.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.
- ROTATION CHECK: position 59 -> C; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 59 -> C.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Pataliputra remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

Remedial MCQ 60 - Untouchability-term remedial

Which statement is correct?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
A	Every Shudra was an asprishya in the Nikayas	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
B	The term is an NBPW label	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
C	No exclusion existed before the Vishnu Smriti	Distractor	Test chronology, category and absolute wording
D	Severe Chandala stigma is early, but the group term asprishya is attested in a later text	Correct	Test chronology, category and absolute wording

Core teaching / solved analysis

- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Severe Chandala stigma is early, but the group term asprishya is attested in a later text.
- EXPLANATION: Distinguish practice evidence from the date of terminology.
- ELIMINATION: reject anachronism, category collapse, source overreach and absolute claims.

- ROTATION CHECK: position 60 -> D; strict A-B-C-D sequence.
- EVIDENCE RULE: identify the named text, site, artefact, social term or institution that supports the answer and state what it cannot prove.

Memory hook: 60 -> D.

Must-know facts

- Coverage area: Untouchability-term remedial.
- Every option is checked against chronology and evidence type.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by familiar keywords. **Correct:** Define the category and test the source.
- **Wrong:** Ignore words such as all, only, identical or automatically. **Correct:** Absolute wording frequently creates the distractor.

Mains/PYQ use: MCQ loop: answer -> explain -> eliminate -> state one caveat.

Study link: Topic 13 consolidated practice.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2026 printed Q3: Pali coin evidence

Pali texts contain early definite coin terms and archaeological finds include mostly silver punch-marked coins. The question asks whether this evidence is associated with both urban life and transition to a money economy.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Statement I	kahapana, nikkha, kamsa, kakanika in Pali texts	Literary evidence for money vocabulary	Terms require context
Statement II	Punch-marked coins at many sites	Material corroboration	Distribution is uneven
Association 1	Emergence of urban life	Coins accompany wider town/trade growth	Coinage alone does not cause urbanism
Association 2	Transition to money economy	Qualitative change in transactions	Barter and kind continue

Core teaching / solved analysis

- VERIFIED QUESTION: local official Set-A paper; the paper itself prints this as Q3 although a repository routing ledger misnumbers it.
- ANSWER: C - Both 1 and 2.
- KEY STATUS: locally held 2026 Series-A key is provisional; printed Q3 is marked C.
- EXPLANATION: Textual coin names and archaeological punch-marked coins converge in an urbanising, increasingly monetised economy.
- LIMIT: The association does not mean universal coin use or a monocausal urban transition.

Memory hook: 2026 printed Q3 = C; provisional key.

Must-know facts

- VERIFIED QUESTION: local official Set-A paper; the paper itself prints this as Q3 although a repository routing ledger misnumbers it.
- ANSWER: C - Both 1 and 2.
- KEY STATUS: locally held 2026 Series-A key is provisional; printed Q3 is marked C.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Follow the routing-ledger number when it conflicts with the printed paper. **Correct:** The official paper controls the question number and wording.

Mains/PYQ use: Prelims elimination: distinguish association from exclusive causation.

Study link: Local 2026 paper/key; Topic 02 verified-PYQ audit.

Verified adjacent Prelims PYQ - 2025 Set A Q17: regions and rivers

Pairs: Asmaka-Godavari; Kamboja-Vipas; Avanti-Mahanadi; Kosala-Sarayu. The demand tests political geography surrounding the mahajanapada world.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Asmaka-Godavari	Assaka/Ashmaka in Godavari corridor	Correct	Capital traditions vary
Kamboja-Vipas	North-western frontier versus Beas pairing	Incorrect	Do not match by vague proximity
Avanti-Mahanadi	Malwa/Narmada orientation	Incorrect	Avanti had northern/southern centres
Kosala-Sarayu	Sarayu-linked Kosala	Correct	Textual geography changes over time

Core teaching / solved analysis

- OFFICIAL LOCAL SET-A KEY: B - only two pairs are correct.
- The correct pairs are Asmaka-Godavari and Kosala-Sarayu.
- The question is adjacent rather than exclusively Topic 13; it anchors the territorial geography of early states.
- ELIMINATION: locate the polity's core river basin before testing the pair.

Memory hook: A-K-A-K: yes, no, no, yes.

Must-know facts

- OFFICIAL LOCAL SET-A KEY: B - only two pairs are correct.
- The correct pairs are Asmaka-Godavari and Kosala-Sarayu.
- The question is adjacent rather than exclusively Topic 13; it anchors the territorial geography of early states.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Every north-western polity can be paired with any Punjab river. **Correct:** Use securely attested regional geography, not proximity guessing.

Mains/PYQ use: Map-based evidence can support a state-formation answer without becoming environmental determinism.

Study link: Topic 11 primary ownership; local 2025 official key.

Verified adjacent Prelims PYQ - 2024 Set A Q54: Buddha epithets

Which of Nayaputta, Shakyamuni and Tathagata were epithets of Gautama Buddha?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Nayaputta/Nataputta	Pali designation associated with Mahavira	Not Buddha	Transliteration varies
Shakyamuni	Sage of the Shakyas	Buddha epithet	Connects clan identity
Tathagata	Common Buddhist self-designation/title	Buddha epithet	Doctrinal nuances vary
Answer	2 and 3 only	Option B	Official Set-A key verified

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: official UPSC 2024 Set-A key verified locally.
- ANSWER: B - 2 and 3 only.
- RELEVANCE: Shakyamuni anchors the Buddha in a Sakya gana lineage; the question itself is doctrinal/identity focused.
- LIMIT: Epithets do not prove the political constitution of the Sakya territory.

Memory hook: Nayaputta = Mahavira; Shakyamuni + Tathagata = Buddha.

Must-know facts

- ANSWER STATUS: official UPSC 2024 Set-A key verified locally.
- ANSWER: B - 2 and 3 only.
- RELEVANCE: Shakyamuni anchors the Buddha in a Sakya gana lineage; the question itself is doctrinal/identity focused.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** All familiar Pali religious titles refer to Buddha. **Correct:** First separate Buddhist and Jaina identities.

Mains/PYQ use: Use only as an identity bridge; do not turn an epithet PYQ into a state-theory answer.

Study link: Topic 10 primary ownership; local 2024 paper/key.

Verified adjacent Mains PYQ - 2024 GS-I Q1

Underline the changes in the field of society and economy from the Rig Vedic to the Later Vedic period. Answer in 150 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Economy	Cattle-centred agro-pastoral -> more settled plough cultivation	Production base shifts	Pastoral continuity remains
Polity	jana/assemblies -> stronger kingship and janapada	Territoriality grows	Full mahajanapada bureaucracy lies later
Society	Emergent differentiation -> sharper varna/patriarchy	Hierarchy elaborates	Normative texts are elite
Boundary	PGW/iron versus later NBPW/coins	Protects chronology	Regional overlap exists

Core teaching / solved analysis

- DEMAND: compare change, not describe two periods in separate lists.
- THESIS: Later Vedic society became more agrarian, territorial and stratified, but the transition was gradual and regionally uneven.
- MODEL: Cattle retained value while plough cultivation, crop vocabulary and settled production expanded. Jana and vis identities continued, but janapada territoriality, stronger kingship, bali and royal sacrifices enlarged extraction and authority. Varna duties, Brahmana-Kshatriya privilege, gotra and patriarchal household norms became more explicit. Occupational diversity increased, though NBPW cities and punch-marked coins belong mainly to the following early-historic horizon. Thus the Later Vedic phase supplied agrarian, social and territorial preconditions rather than a complete Buddha-age state.
- **Why this earns marks:** It answers the comparison directly, uses jana, janapada, bali, varna, PGW/NBPW and avoids projecting later urban institutions backward.

Memory hook: A-T-S-B: Agriculture, Territory, Stratification, Boundary.

Must-know facts

- DEMAND: compare change, not describe two periods in separate lists.

- **THESIS:** Later Vedic society became more agrarian, territorial and stratified, but the transition was gradual and regionally uneven.
- **MODEL:** Cattle retained value while plough cultivation, crop vocabulary and settled production expanded. Jana and vis identities continued, but janapada territoriality, stronger kingship, bali and royal sacrifices enlarged extraction and authority. Varna duties, Brahmana-Kshatriya privilege, gotra and patriarchal household norms became more explicit. Occupational diversity increased, though NBPW cities and punch-marked coins belong mainly to the following early-historic horizon. Thus the Later Vedic phase supplied agrarian, social and territorial preconditions rather than a complete Buddha-age state.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Insert punch-marked coins as a central Later Vedic feature. **Correct:** Keep coins/NBPW as the subsequent early-historic boundary.

Mains/PYQ use: This PYQ supplies the immediate baseline for Topic 13 comparison.

Study link: Topic 09 primary ownership; local 2024 GS-I paper.

Verified adjacent Mains PYQ - 2023 GS-I Q1

Explain the role of geographical factors towards the development of Ancient India. Answer in 150 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Floodplain	Ganga-Son-Gandak system	Agriculture, transport and Magadhan core	Requires labour and statecraft
Routes	North-west passes; Uttarapatha/Dakshinapatha	Contact, trade and invasion	Not cultural replacement
Resources	Forests, elephants, iron-bearing zones	Military and production opportunity	No simple monopoly
Coasts/ivers	Monsoon seas and navigable rivers	Long-distance circulation	Seasonal/technological limits

Core teaching / solved analysis

- **DEMAND:** explain causal roles across regions, not list physiography.
- **THESIS:** Geography created corridors, resources and regional ecological bases, but historical development depended on technology, labour and political organisation.
- **MODEL:** The north-western passes and Indus corridors enabled exchange and incursions; the Ganga alluvium and river transport supported dense cultivation, towns and Magadha's core; plateau/forest zones supplied minerals, timber and elephants while also sustaining communities that resisted state expansion; coasts and monsoon navigation supported later maritime exchange. Yet Kaushambi, Rajgir and Pataliputra became political centres only through labour, fortification, taxation and strategy. Geography therefore structured opportunity and constraint rather than determining outcomes.
- **Why this earns marks:** It uses four geographical mechanisms, names Magadhan and urban examples, and explicitly rejects determinism.

Memory hook: G-O-M: Geography, Opportunity, Mediation.

Must-know facts

- **DEMAND:** explain causal roles across regions, not list physiography.
- **THESIS:** Geography created corridors, resources and regional ecological bases, but historical development depended on technology, labour and political organisation.
- **MODEL:** The north-western passes and Indus corridors enabled exchange and incursions; the Ganga alluvium and river transport supported dense cultivation, towns and Magadha's core; plateau/forest zones supplied minerals, timber and elephants while also sustaining communities that resisted state expansion; coasts and monsoon navigation supported later maritime exchange. Yet Kaushambi, Rajgir and Pataliputra became political

centres only through labour, fortification, taxation and strategy. Geography therefore structured opportunity and constraint rather than determining outcomes.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Fertile land automatically produces empire. **Correct:** Show mediation by labour, technology, institutions and strategy.

Mains/PYQ use: Use the Magadha case as one evidence unit, not the whole answer.

Study link: Topic 03 primary ownership; local 2023 GS-I paper.

Original solved 10-marker 1 - Multi-causal state formation

Explain why state formation in the Age of the Buddha cannot be reduced to a single technological or ecological cause. Answer in 150 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Agrarian base	NBPW-phase settlement growth and iron tools	Surplus capacity	Iron not sufficient
Fiscal institutions	bhaga/bali/shulka; headmen/officials	Mobilisation	Rates/reach varied
Coercion/strategy	forts, army, elephants, diplomacy	Expansion and order	Numbers/narratives source-bound

Core teaching / solved analysis

- **DEMAND:** explain multi-causality and reject technological/ecological determinism.
- **THESIS:** State formation arose when production, extraction, coercion, urban concentration and legitimacy reinforced one another.
- **MODEL ANSWER:** Iron tools and fertile alluvium enlarged cultivation in parts of the Ganga basin, but they created only an opportunity. NBPW settlements and towns such as Kaushambi and Rajgir depended on labour, craft specialisation and routes. Monarchies converted produce into power through bhaga, bali, tolls, village headmen and differentiated officials; variable Dharmasutra revenue rates show that extraction was not uniform. Fortifications, permanent troops, elephants and diplomacy enabled rulers to defend and expand territory, while Kshatriya lineage and Brahmana/renunciant legitimation justified rule. Gana-sanghas in the same ecology followed a different institutional path, proving that resources did not dictate monarchy. Thus state formation was conjunctural: ecology and technology mattered through fiscal, military, political and ideological organisation.
- **Why this earns marks:** It uses three named evidence clusters, explains mechanisms, compares an alternative political form and gives a qualified verdict within 10-marker scope.

Memory hook: Claim -> evidence -> significance -> qualification.

Must-know facts

- Evidence density is scaled to marks.
- Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive. **Correct:** Decode explain, compare, analyse or critically assess.
- **Wrong:** List evidence without interpretation. **Correct:** State what each named unit proves and its limit.

Mains/PYQ use: A strong 10-marker names at least three mechanisms and one counter-example.

Study link: Topic 13 answer-worthiness architecture.

Original solved 10-marker 2 - Varna and lived society

Distinguish varna, jati, occupation and class in the society of c. 600-400 BCE. Answer in 150 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Varna	Dharmasutra fourfold duties	Normative ritual rank	Not complete practice
Jati/occupation	Pali high/low jatis and named crafts	Lived group/work identity	Early rigidity uncertain
Class	gahapati, setthi, dalidda/mahabhoga	Resource/wealth inequality	Does not erase ritual rank

Core teaching / solved analysis

- DEMAND: define and differentiate, then show interaction.
- THESIS: Buddha-age identity was multi-dimensional; the four-varna norm neither disappeared nor described the entire social field.
- MODEL ANSWER: Varna was the Brahmanical fourfold normative order assigning ritual and social duties to Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya and Shudra. Jati denoted numerous hereditary social groups whose rank, marriage and local operation did not fit one fourfold scale; Pali references to Chandala, rathakara and other occupational jatis illustrate this complexity. Occupation meant actual work-smith, potter, trader, cultivator or kammakara-which could diverge from varna prescriptions, as apad-dharma concessions acknowledge. Class referred to unequal control over land, wealth and office: a gahapati or setthi could wield economic and patronage power without Brahmana ritual rank. Kula, gotra, gender and region further shaped status. Therefore varna provided a legitimating macro-schema, while jati, occupation, class and lineage organised much of lived society.
- **Why this earns marks:** It directly differentiates four categories, uses precise Pali/Brahmanical terms and ends with their relationship rather than a synonym list.

Memory hook: Claim -> evidence -> significance -> qualification.

Must-know facts

- Evidence density is scaled to marks.
- Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive. **Correct:** Decode explain, compare, analyse or critically assess.
- **Wrong:** List evidence without interpretation. **Correct:** State what each named unit proves and its limit.

Mains/PYQ use: Use one definition and one named evidence unit per category.

Study link: Topic 13 answer-worthiness architecture.

Original solved 10-marker 3 - Gahapati and setthi

What does the prominence of gahapati and setthi reveal about social change in the Age of the Buddha? Answer in 150 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
gahapati	Pali wealthy producer/property-holder	Rural surplus and household power	Not every householder
setthi	Urban financier/business elite	Money, credit and royal access	Not interchangeable
Patronage	Jetavana/lay donor and puga traditions	Institutional link to sangha	Exemplary texts

Core teaching / solved analysis

- DEMAND: infer social change from terminology.

- **THESIS:** Gahapati and setthi show that wealth and control of productive resources became independent, though not equal, axes of status alongside varna.
- **MODEL ANSWER:** In early Pali usage the gahapati was more than a married householder: he was often a wealthy property-holder and producer, especially connected with land and household labour. The setthi was a high-level urban businessman/financier linked to trade, credit and kings. Their distinction-and the compound setthi-gahapati for a person spanning landed and urban enterprise-reveals an economy in which rural surplus, towns and money generated new elites. Donor traditions such as Anathapindika's association with Jetavana and puga provisioning of monastics show how such wealth sustained religious institutions and bought prestige. Yet these categories did not abolish ritual hierarchy: economic influence coexisted with Brahmana and Kshatriya rank claims. They therefore expose the gap between a four-varna model and a socially differentiated urban-agrarian practice.
- **Why this earns marks:** It defines both terms, gives patronage evidence, explains status contradiction and includes the exemplary-source limit.

Memory hook: Claim -> evidence -> significance -> qualification.

Must-know facts

- Evidence density is scaled to marks.
- Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive. **Correct:** Decode explain, compare, analyse or critically assess.
- **Wrong:** List evidence without interpretation. **Correct:** State what each named unit proves and its limit.

Mains/PYQ use: Turn vocabulary into an argument about wealth, status and institutions.

Study link: Topic 13 answer-worthiness architecture.

Original solved 15-marker 1 - Monarchy and gana-sangha

Compare the political institutions and social bases of monarchies and gana-sanghas in the Age of the Buddha.
Answer in 250 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Authority	Hereditary king versus assembly/chief	Different concentration	Both had elite councils
Fiscal/military	Central treasury/standing force versus clan contingents	Expansion capacity	Ganas could be cohesive
Social base	Royal-ritual coalition versus Kshatriya lineage oligarchy	Different inclusion	Non-elites subordinate in both
Evidence	Pali texts, Panini, Mahaparinibbana traditions	Institutional reconstruction	Literary/redaction limits

Core teaching / solved analysis

- **DEMAND:** compare institutions and social bases, not merely define two forms.
- **THESIS:** Monarchies and gana-sanghas represented alternative early state forms; monarchies concentrated fiscal-military command, while ganas institutionalised deliberation among a restricted Kshatriya oligarchy.
- **MODEL ANSWER - AUTHORITY:** In Magadha and Kosala, a hereditary king stood at the apex, assisted by ministers, military officers, revenue personnel and village headmen. Ganas such as Vajji, Malla and Sakya lacked a single hereditary monarch; aristocratic rajas met in a santhagara, used procedures associated with salakas and delegated daily business to chiefs/smaller councils. These details derive mainly from Buddhist texts and later analogies, so exact procedure remains uncertain.
- **MODEL ANSWER - CAPACITY:** Monarchical claims over bhaga, bali and tolls supported treasuries, forts and more permanent armies. Gana military power rested more on lineage chiefs and their contingents. This could produce solidarity, but the Mahaparinibbana Sutta also makes internal concord-and its diplomatic subversion-a

decisive vulnerability.

- **MODEL ANSWER - SOCIAL BASE:** Monarchies combined Kshatriya coercive authority with Brahmana advisers/ritual legitimacy and wealthy gahapati-setthi support. Ganas privileged heads of leading Kshatriya families; women, farmers, artisans, wage workers and slaves lacked political participation. Brahmana purohitas appear less central.
- **VERDICT:** The contrast is not despotism versus democracy. Both were elite orders, but monarchy's concentrated revenue and force often proved better suited to territorial expansion, while gana deliberation remained socially exclusionary.
- **Why this earns marks:** It compares four axes, names institutions and sources, explains causal consequences and rejects modern-democracy projection.

Memory hook: Claim -> evidence -> significance -> qualification.

Must-know facts

- Evidence density is scaled to marks.
- Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive. **Correct:** Decode explain, compare, analyse or critically assess.
- **Wrong:** List evidence without interpretation. **Correct:** State what each named unit proves and its limit.

Mains/PYQ use: A comparison answer needs parallel axes and a verdict on capacity plus inclusion.

Study link: Topic 13 answer-worthiness architecture.

Original solved 15-marker 2 - Norm and practice

Examine the gap between varna ideology and social practice in north India during c. 600-400 BCE. Answer in 250 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Norm	Dharmasutra duties, initiation and graded law	Hierarchical project	Regional/date debates
Deviation	anuloma/pratiloma; apad-dharma	Marriage/work crossed ideals	Not equality
Lived categories	jati, kula, occupation, gahapati/setthi	Multi-axis society	Elite text bias
Exclusion	Chandala and labour terms	Stigma/dependence	Voices largely absent

Core teaching / solved analysis

- **DEMAND:** examine the gap without claiming either complete rigidity or irrelevance.
- **THESIS:** Varna was a powerful legitimating norm, but its own exceptions and the social vocabulary of Pali texts reveal a society organised through jati, occupation, lineage, wealth and gender as well.
- **MODEL ANSWER - NORM:** Dharmasutras assign Vedic learning/sacrifice to Brahmanas, protection to Kshatriyas, cultivation/trade to Vaishyas and service to Shudras; upanayana and graded legal rules embody hierarchy. Yet these are normative works with debated dates and regions.
- **MODEL ANSWER - PRACTICE:** Their classification of anuloma and pratiloma unions admits inter-varna marriage, while apad-dharma permits occupational crossing in adversity. The varna-samkara theory itself tries to fit proliferating jatis into the fourfold model. Pali texts identify many people through crafts, kula and jati rather than Vaishya/Shudra, and distinguish the landed gahapati from the urban setthi. Dasa, kammakara and Chandala evidence reveals forms of dependence and stigma not captured by a simple fourfold diagram.
- **MODEL ANSWER - QUALIFICATION:** None of this means fluid equality. Birth, endogamy, purity, patrilineal property and political lineage exerted real force; wealth could raise influence without erasing ritual rank.

- VERDICT: Varna should be read as a regulatory and legitimating macro-schema interacting with, not fully determining, lived social differentiation.
- **Why this earns marks:** It cites rules and exceptions, uses Pali categories, preserves hierarchy and explicitly separates prescription from practice.

Memory hook: Claim -> evidence -> significance -> qualification.

Must-know facts

- Evidence density is scaled to marks.
- Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive. **Correct:** Decode explain, compare, analyse or critically assess.
- **Wrong:** List evidence without interpretation. **Correct:** State what each named unit proves and its limit.

Mains/PYQ use: The best answer proves the gap from the normative texts themselves.

Study link: Topic 13 answer-worthiness architecture.

Original solved 15-marker 3 - Family, property and gender

Analyse how changes in property and social hierarchy affected family and gender relations in the Age of the Buddha. Answer in 250 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Property	Gift/sale of land; inheritance traditions	Raises lineage stakes	Text-heavy evidence
Marriage	Grihya/Dharmasutra classifications	Controls alliance and descent	Custom varied
Gender	domestic ritual, stri-dhana roots, nuns	Agency within constraint	Elite male sources
Household labour	family, slaves, servants, kammakaras	Production and dependence	Scale unknown

Core teaching / solved analysis

- DEMAND: connect macro-economic change to household/gender mechanisms.
- THESIS: As land, surplus and inherited status became more important, patriarchal control over marriage, sexuality and succession intensified, even while texts reveal regional variation and religious alternatives.
- MODEL ANSWER - PROPERTY/LINAGE: Buddhist texts refer to land gift/sale, large estates and heirless property claimed by kings; inheritance usually prioritised sons and male kin. Kula, gotra and sapinda rules organised descent and marriage, making control of legitimate heirs crucial.
- MODEL ANSWER - MARRIAGE/HOUSEHOLD: Grihyasutras systematised domestic rites and Dharmasutras graded eight marriage forms. Their discussion of dowry, bride-price, cross-cousin custom, widow remarriage and niyoga reveals diverse practice under a stronger normative project. The household joined production, ritual and reproduction and could include dependants, slaves and wage workers.
- MODEL ANSWER - WOMEN: Women participated in some domestic rites and possessed forms of movable property that developed into stri-dhana, but major sacrificial agency and inheritance remained male-centred. Ambapali and donor traditions show public/economic visibility; bhikkhuni and Jaina nun orders created alternatives to marriage, yet gender hierarchy persisted.
- VERDICT: Property and hierarchy strengthened patriarchy, but neither women's experience nor regional custom was uniform.
- **Why this earns marks:** It links cause to household mechanism, uses kin/legal/social evidence and balances agency with source and representativeness limits.

Memory hook: Claim -> evidence -> significance -> qualification.

Must-know facts

- Evidence density is scaled to marks.
- Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive. **Correct:** Decode explain, compare, analyse or critically assess.
- **Wrong:** List evidence without interpretation. **Correct:** State what each named unit proves and its limit.

Mains/PYQ use: Property -> lineage -> marriage control -> gender hierarchy is the central causal chain.

Study link: Topic 13 answer-worthiness architecture.

Original solved 20-marker 1 - Cities, kings and renunciants

The Age of the Buddha is best understood through the interaction of cities, kings and renunciants. Discuss. Answer in 350 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Cities	NBPW towns, coins, crafts, routes	Concentrate surplus and social diversity	Regional/site variation
Kings	tax, officials, armies, forts, legitimacy	Mobilise territory	Control uneven
Renunciants	sangha, alms, ethical critique	Alternative authority	Depend on lay society
Interdependence	gahapati/setthi patronage and royal dialogue	Institutional reproduction	No economic reductionism

Core teaching / solved analysis

- **DEMAND:** discuss interaction, not three parallel descriptions.
- **THESIS:** Urbanisation, state formation and renunciation were mutually constitutive: agrarian-urban wealth enabled states and sanghas, states shaped routes and patronage, and renunciants offered ethical responses to hierarchy and attachment.
- **MODEL ANSWER - MATERIAL NETWORK:** Early NBPW horizons, punch-marked coins and sites such as Kaushambi, Rajgir, Vaishali, Shravasti and Pataliputra reveal expanding settlements, crafts and exchange. Pali terms-kahapana, puga, gahapati and setthi-show monetisation, corporate organisation and new elites. Yet pottery did not cause cities; rural food, labour, tools and routes sustained them.
- **MODEL ANSWER - STATE:** Monarchies converted surplus into bhaga, bali, tolls, officials, forts and standing forces. Gana-sanghas represented an alternative oligarchic form, but Magadha's concentrated fiscal-military command and diplomacy favoured expansion. Kshatriya lineage, Brahmana ritual and protection narratives legitimised authority, while rate variation and oppressive-tax stories reveal limits and resistance.
- **MODEL ANSWER - RENUNCIANTS:** Buddhists, Jainas and other shramanas questioned sacrifice, attachment and birth-based spiritual pride. Monastic admission could cross varna backgrounds and offered men and women alternative status. However, slaves required freedom and debtors repayment; sanghas depended on alms, gardens and gifts from kings, gahapatis, setthis and corporate groups.
- **MODEL ANSWER - SOCIAL CONTRADICTION:** The same society sharpened varna, jati, patrilineal inheritance and labour dependence while producing ethical critiques and new donor identities. Renunciation was therefore within the urban-agrarian world, not outside it.
- **VERDICT:** 'Cities, kings and renunciants' is persuasive if treated as an interacting triangle and qualified by villages, forests, women, labourers and regional variation.
- **Why this earns marks:** It integrates material, political, social and religious evidence, uses more than eight named units, states counter-evidence and answers the interaction demanded.

Memory hook: Claim -> evidence -> significance -> qualification.

Must-know facts

- Evidence density is scaled to marks.
- Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive. **Correct:** Decode explain, compare, analyse or critically assess.
- **Wrong:** List evidence without interpretation. **Correct:** State what each named unit proves and its limit.

Mains/PYQ use: Use an interaction triangle and ensure every arrow has evidence plus a limit.

Study link: Topic 13 answer-worthiness architecture.

Original solved 20-marker 2 - Did Buddhism and Jainism abolish caste?

Critically assess the extent to which Buddhism and Jainism challenged social hierarchy in the Age of the Buddha.
Answer in 350 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Doctrine	conduct/karma/renunciation over birth claims	Ethical critique	Traditions differ
Institution	cross-varna admission; monks/nuns	Alternative status	Admission/gender rules
Lay society	gahapati/setthi/royal patrons; jati persists	Broad social base	No legal abolition
Texts	Kshatriya-Brahmana debates; Vinaya	Evidence of challenge and accommodation	Sectarian/monastic agendas

Core teaching / solved analysis

- **DEMAND:** critically assess extent-state challenge, reach and limits.
- **THESIS:** Buddhism and Jainism weakened the religious monopoly of birth and widened paths to merit and liberation, but neither dissolved the social structures of household, property, labour, gender and jati.
- **MODEL ANSWER - CHALLENGE:** Both traditions centred ethical conduct, self-discipline and renunciation rather than Vedic sacrifice. Buddhist/Jaina texts denied automatic Brahmana spiritual superiority and sometimes ranked Kshatriya above Brahmana. Sanghas admitted people from varied backgrounds; nun orders created a religious path beyond marriage. Teaching in Middle Indo-Aryan traditions and mobile networks widened access.
- **MODEL ANSWER - SOCIAL APPEAL:** Kings, artisans, gahapatis, setthis and corporate groups appear as patrons. Dana allowed wealth to be converted into merit, while monastic rules and stable establishments connected cities, routes and lay households.
- **MODEL ANSWER - LIMITS:** The sangha did not legislate lay caste abolition. Varna and jati remained social reference points; householders retained property and inheritance systems. Slaves needed manumission and debtors repayment before admission, acknowledging existing lay claims. Women entered orders under unequal institutional rules. Pali texts themselves use high/low jati language and preserve stigma against Chandalas. Jain lay discipline similarly operated within household and commercial society.
- **MODEL ANSWER - QUALIFICATION:** Merchant support was important but cannot reduce either religion to a class ideology; metaphysical, ethical and soteriological concerns had independent force.
- **VERDICT:** Their achievement was a powerful ethical and institutional critique with partial social openings, not the abolition of hierarchy. The answer must separate doctrine, monastic membership and lay practice.
- **Why this earns marks:** It evaluates degree across four levels, uses rules about slaves/debtors/women and patron categories, and avoids both celebratory abolition and cynical economic reductionism.

Memory hook: Claim -> evidence -> significance -> qualification.

Must-know facts

- Evidence density is scaled to marks.
- Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive. **Correct:** Decode explain, compare, analyse or critically assess.
- **Wrong:** List evidence without interpretation. **Correct:** State what each named unit proves and its limit.

Mains/PYQ use: Critically assess through doctrine, institution, lay society and long-term limit.

Study link: Topic 13 answer-worthiness architecture.

Original solved 20-marker 3 - Reconstructing society from difficult sources

How far can textual and archaeological sources reconstruct state and society in the Age of the Buddha? Discuss with historiographical perspectives. Answer in 350 words.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limit
Buddhist/Jaina	Nikayas, Vinaya, canonical traditions	Institutions/social vocabulary	Composite/sectarian
Brahmanical	Grihya/Dharmasutras, Panini	Norms, rites, terms	Prescription/date/region
Material	NBPW, towns, forts, tools, coins	Production/settlement/exchange	Cannot name identities alone
Historiography	Sharma, Chakravarti, Upinder, Jayaswal	Competing explanatory lenses	Each selects evidence

Core teaching / solved analysis

- **DEMAND:** evaluate source capacity and limits, then explain how historiography uses them.
- **THESIS:** The period can be reconstructed with unusual richness only through controlled triangulation; no source class independently yields a complete social map.
- **MODEL ANSWER - TEXTS:** Early Nikayas/Vinaya preserve gana procedures, gahapati/setthi, labour, donation and renunciation, but are composite monastic texts. Jatakas in present form are later and best used for corroboration/long-term perspective. Jaina sources provide alternative political and renunciant memories but face dating/redaction problems. Panini supplies precise incidental vocabulary; Grihya/Dharmasutras reveal Brahmanical regulation of marriage, varna and inheritance, not automatic practice.
- **MODEL ANSWER - MATERIAL:** NBPW, settlement hierarchies, Kaushambi tools/ramparts, Rajgir defences, early Pataliputra palisades and punch-marked coins securely illuminate urbanisation, production, defence and exchange. They cannot by themselves identify a dynasty, varna or constitutional form; famous later Kumrahar remains must not be backdated.
- **MODEL ANSWER - HISTORIOGRAPHY:** R. S. Sharma's materialism explains surplus, class, taxation and state, but risks iron determinism. Uma Chakravarti's work on gahapati and patriarchy links household/property to social formation. Upinder Singh's 'cities, kings and renunciants' model integrates multiple evidence classes and stresses mosaic chronology. K. P. Jayaswal recovered gana traditions but sometimes modernised their democracy.
- **MODEL ANSWER - METHOD:** Strong claims arise when independent evidence converges-Pali coin terms with punch-marked coins, or urban texts with settlement archaeology. Contradiction/silence must remain visible, especially for women, slaves and forest groups.
- **VERDICT:** Reconstruction is substantial but graded: strongest for material-economic patterns and elite institutions, weaker for prevalence, chronology of redaction and subordinated voices.
- **Why this earns marks:** It compares five source classes, uses named sites/texts/scholars, evaluates each and ends with a graded reliability verdict.

Memory hook: Claim -> evidence -> significance -> qualification.

Must-know facts

- Evidence density is scaled to marks.
- Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive. **Correct:** Decode explain, compare, analyse or critically assess.
- **Wrong:** List evidence without interpretation. **Correct:** State what each named unit proves and its limit.

Mains/PYQ use: Never write a source list without stating what each source can and cannot prove.

Study link: Topic 13 answer-worthiness architecture.